


‘Irfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers



Book Two · Expanded edition

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Seeking, not powers

Many of us first meet the verse at a wedding. The families have gathered, the nikah is about to be read, and someone recites a line of the Quran about the affection and mercy that God places between husband and wife. We nod, because it is beautiful and because it is true. Then the sweets come round, and the verse goes back on the shelf.

But the verse does not end with affection and mercy. It ends with a remark that is easy to miss: there are signs in this, it says, *for a people who reflect*. Not for everyone. Only for some. The verses around it say the same thing again and again: signs for those who know, for those who listen, for those who use their reason. It is as if the Quran were telling us, gently, that we have been looking at God's signs all our lives without quite seeing them.

This chapter asks what has gone wrong with our seeing, and whether it can be put right. It asks why a believer who already prays and fasts should want anything more, and what that “more” really is. On the way it clears up a common misunderstanding: that the spiritual path is a road to strange powers. The answer, drawn from the Quran, from Imam ‘Ali (‘a) and from the lectures behind this book, is simpler than that and far more beautiful. The path is a search for God Himself, and for nothing else.

WORDS YOU'LL MEET ‘Irfan · ma‘rifah · ‘arif · muqarrabun · awliya’ Allah



A mysterious word

Sheikh Bahmanpour began his course with a confession. Mysticism, he said, is very mysterious. No one quite knows what it is, and even the mystics are unsure what it really is, “except the real mystics”. It is a good place to start, because it is honest. Most of us carry a vague picture of the mystic: a figure in a cave, a man in a trance, someone who knows secrets the rest of us do not. Very little of that picture survives contact with the Quran.

Part of the difficulty is that mysticism is not an Islamic monopoly. There are Christian, Hindu and Buddhist mystics, and some people with no religion at all feel the same pull. ‘Allama Tabataba’i, one of the great Shia teachers of recent times, says as much. In every revealed religion, and even among idol-worshippers, he writes, “there are individuals who follow the path of gnosis”. He describes that path as “a way of understanding the inner facts of religion instead of being contented with its outward and perceptible form”¹.

If the longing is universal, then a Muslim who sets out on it needs to know which road he is on. People are drawn to the inner life for very different reasons, and not all of them lead to God. So before anything else we have to ask what we are talking about, who the true mystics are, and what they want. The Islamic tradition has its own name for the path, *‘Irfan*, and for the one who walks it, *‘arif*. Both words point to knowing.

ع WORD STUDY: ‘IRFAN AND MA‘RIFAH

‘Irfan, *ma‘rifah*, *‘arif* and its plural *‘urafa*’ belong to one family of words about knowing. An *‘arif* is, quite simply, someone who knows. “Mystic” is a general term, used of Christians, Hindus and Buddhists alike, but *‘arif* is the Islamic word, and it carries a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line clearly. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The *‘arif* “wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it”². *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (‘a), puts the same idea in a single line: “There is no way to Allah except via knowledge”³. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from the knowledge we gain from books, is the subject of Chapter 3.

¹ Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

² Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

³ *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari‘a), p. 9.



Two reasons to train the soul

Everyone who takes the inner life seriously ends up training the self: watching it, denying it, disciplining it. But self-training can serve very different ends. Some people train the soul in order to gain power. They want to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, to explore the hidden world of the human soul so that they can master it. Mohammad Ali Shomali gives the example of people who work to strengthen the power of the soul so that they can do things not ordinarily possible. In doing so, he notes, they lose touch with everyday life, which is not what Muslims are asked to do⁴.

The Islamic path is not about this. It is about catching the signs of Allah: becoming sensitive to them, and learning to hear and to see. The masters of the Shia tradition are firm on the point. In the lectures of ‘Allama Tabataba’i recorded in *Kernel of the Kernels*, the traveller is told plainly that he “has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities”. He may not perform austerities or recite invocations to gain such powers as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others⁵. The reason is not that such things are impossible. It is that whoever seeks them “does not move on the path of the Beloved’s pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God”. In fact it is his own self that he worships, “though he may not admit it by word of mouth”⁶. The *Kernel* ties this to a searching question in the Quran: “Have you seen him who has taken his desire to be his god?” (Q 25:43).

◆ WHO'S WHO: ‘ALLAMA TABATABA’I

Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba’i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a great commentary on the Quran in twenty volumes⁷. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihirani describes him as having flown “with the two wings of knowledge and action”. He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi. After years of philosophical argument he “came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur’an”, which became dearer to him than any other study⁸. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihirani’s record of the first lectures on ethics and gnosis

⁴Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 12.

⁵‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), pp. 28–29.

⁶‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 29.

⁷Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.

⁸‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 8.

⁹‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihirani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 9.



that Tabataba'i gave to students in the seminary of Qum in 1949–50⁹. He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*¹⁰, from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the same test from his own teacher, Ayatullah Shahabadi. The measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller's "spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid"¹¹.

So there are two quite different journeys that can both be called "mysticism". One aims at power. The other aims at God. And the second is hard: "exhausting, time consuming, life consuming". That raises an obvious question. Why would anyone take it on?

Why go beyond the wajib?

It is a fair question, and most of us have asked it, at least privately. Suppose I pray my five daily prayers, fast in Ramadan, pay my zakat and go to hajj once in my life. Suppose I do all that is *wajib*, all that is obligatory. Will I not reach *janna*? And if I will, why should I wake for *salat al-layl*, keep the recommended fasts, or take on the long and difficult striving of the inner path? Why work so hard when the door is already open?

Some go further. There have always been Muslims, jurists and activists among them, who are firmly against mysticism. Their argument is simple. Follow what the *shari'a*, the sacred law, has told you and you will reach Paradise; there is no other way. Anything else is "made up by some mystics according to their vibes and wishes".

The question deserves a real answer, and one helpful answer comes from the way Islam itself is built. Shomali points out that a Muslim's life is guided by two sets of rules: *fiqh*, the law, and *akhlaq*, ethics. "The obligatory rules of Fiqh are concerned with the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection," he writes. For those "aspiring to new heights", the further guidance lies in *akhlaq*¹². His example is the very prayer we started with: the night prayer,

¹⁰Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

¹¹Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

¹²Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, pp. 17–18.



“while not mandatory in fiqh, it is compulsory in akhlaq”¹³.

None of this means that the obligatory is not enough to be saved. The lectures grant that a believer who follows the shari‘a and does what is required is on a sound path and will reach janna: “that’s fair enough”, for ordinary believers. The point is that the wajib is the floor, not the ceiling, and that the Quran describes people who have gone further. Imam Khomeini describes the same ladder in terms of *taqwa*, the awareness of God that guards a person. “For ordinary men taqwa is with respect to the forbidden things; for the elect it is vis-a-vis sensual pleasures”, and so on upwards, through the world, through love of the self, and beyond¹⁴. None of this belittles the floor. A genuine seeker’s devotion, as Imam Khomeini insists, “is within the bounds of the Shari’ah”¹⁵. The path does not go around the law. It goes on from it.

But there is a simpler way to settle the matter than argument. We can ask what the Quran says, and open it at Surah al-Rum.

Signs for some

Surah al-Rum, the thirtieth surah, contains a remarkable run of verses. Each begins with one of His signs, and each ends by naming the kind of person for whom the sign is meant.

¹³Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 18.

¹⁴Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 199.

¹⁵Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.



وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ أَنْ خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مِنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا لِتَسْكُنُوا إِلَيْهَا وَجَعَلَ بَيْنَكُمْ
 مَوَدَّةً وَرَحْمَةً إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾ وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ
 خَلْقَ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافِ أَلْسِنَتِكُمْ وَالْوُكُوفِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ
 لِلْعَالِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

*And of His signs is that He created for you mates from your own selves
 that you may take comfort in them, and He ordained affection and
 mercy between you. There are indeed signs in that for a people who re-
 flect.*

*Among His signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the
 difference of your languages and colours. There are indeed signs in
 that for those who know.*

Quran 30:21-22

Read them slowly and the endings begin to press. Take the first. When we look at the love between a husband and wife, do we see a sign of God? If we are honest, we are more likely to see the work of Shaytan. The sign is there, but it is for “a people who reflect”.

The second verse speaks of the variety of our languages and colours. We are more likely to see in that variety a reason for division than a sign of God. Again the sign is there, but it is “for those who know”. Not most people, then; not even most pious people, nor most of those who are careful about the shari’a. The next two verses continue the pattern.



ج
وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ مَنَامُكُمْ بِاللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَابْتِغَاؤُكُمْ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ
لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾ وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ يُرِيكُمُ الْبَرْقَ خَوْفًا وَطَمَعًا
وَيَنْزِلُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَيُحْيِي بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ
لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

*And of His signs is your sleep by night and day, and your pursuit of
His bounty. There are indeed signs in that for a people who listen.
And of His signs is that He shows you the lightning, arousing fear and
hope, and He sends down water from the sky, and with it revives the
earth after its death. There are indeed signs in that for people who ex-
ercise their reason.*

Quran 30:23-24

Sleep and the daily search for a living are signs “for a people who listen”. Do we listen? If we really heard, why are we not broken by these signs, as the prophets and the friends of God are broken when they see them? The rain that brings dead earth back to life is a sign for those who use their reason, and we have all seen rain.

Sheikh Bahmanpour admits that when he reads these verses he feels almost insulted. The Quran seems to be saying to us: you do not reflect, you do not know, you do not listen, you do not understand. And the charge comes back elsewhere. In another verse God asks who but He could bring light if He made the night last until the Day of Resurrection, and ends: “Will you not listen?” (Q 28:71). Most of us accept that there are signs simply out of obedience: the Quran says there are signs, so there are signs. But we do not catch them. Another verse puts the whole situation in one line.

وَكَلَّيْنِ مَنْ آيَةٌ فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ
﴿١٠٥﴾

*How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass
by while they are disregarding of it!*

Quran 12:105



What does it mean to see a sign? ‘Allama Tabataba’i uses the image of a red light. A driver who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and “what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator”. Next to God, he says, the world is like a zero added to one: it “is a nonentity and does not add anything to His Essence”. He adds a detail that matters for everything that follows. This realisation “does not come through eyes, ears or any other sensory organs or mental faculties, for all organs themselves are mere signs”¹⁶.

So the eyes are not the problem. Something else is.

The receiver inside

Think about what an ear does. It catches sound, and it does that well enough. But behind the ear there is something that does not catch what the ear brings in, “a machine inside which is rust”. The signals reach us; nothing inside us picks them up. A modern reader might call it a receiver. God is broadcasting all the time, and the set inside us is not tuned.

The Quran describes this condition in a verse that can be hard to hear.

وَلَقَدْ ذَرَأْنَا لِجَهَنَّمَ كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الْجِنِّ وَالْإِنسِ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ بَّ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا
وَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ
بِهَا وَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا
كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ أُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْغَافِلُونَ ﴿١٧٩﴾

Certainly We have winnowed out for hell many of the jinn and humans: they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray. It is they who are the heedless.

Quran 7:179

There is a puzzle in it. The verse compares such people to cattle. Yet cattle do see and hear. Shout near a herd and it runs. So what is the comparison? The answer is that seeing and hearing in the ordinary sense only touch the surface of things. Inside a human being there is something that should translate what

¹⁶Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.



we see and hear into its reality. Animals do not have it. We do have it, but in most of us it does not work. Those who reject faith might laugh at the charge that they cannot see; they may claim to see in more detail, and more artistically, than any believer. Yes, the Quran answers, they see, but they do not understand.

Here is the simplest definition of the path in the whole lecture series. [‘Irfan] “is all about making one’s soul to hear, to see and to reflect”, and that “is the summary of Islamic mysticism”. Everything else in this book, the stages, the disciplines and the dangers, is about how to do it. It is not easy: “It needs lots of training.”

The good news is that the receiver is not missing. It is part of how we are made. The *Kernel* opens by saying that the religious urge, the pull towards the unseen, is “part of the innate instincts of the human being”. It is the attraction of the soul “towards the loving Lord, who draws it towards His own infinite and absolute station”¹⁷. Imam Khomeini goes further. Every human heart, believer or materialist, longs for a perfection with no flaw in it. Taken together, he says, all human beings declare: “We are lovers of Absolute Perfection; we are enamored to Absolute Beauty and Majesty”¹⁸. The longing is already there. What is missing is a receiver clear enough to recognise its true object.

Imam ‘Ali (‘a) speaks of exactly this repair. “God has made his remembrance the burnish for your hearts,” he says, and with it “you can hear after your earlier deafness, see after your earlier night-blindness”¹⁹. The rust can be polished away. And once the receiver begins to work, the journey has only *begun*. The path “has a beginning and no end”. What the soul may see and hear after that, only God knows.

Those brought near

If some people’s receivers work and others’ do not, the Quran should say so, and it does. Surah al-Waqi’a divides people into groups on the Last Day, and at the top it places “the Foremost Ones”, who “are the ones brought near [to Allah]” (Q 56:10–11). The Arabic word is *muqarrabun*, and it runs through the whole of this lecture series.

¹⁷‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 4.

¹⁸Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 176.

¹⁹Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.219.1.



What does “brought near” mean? God is not far from anyone. Rather, for these people some veil between them and God has been taken away. They understand far better, and that is why they are called near.

Who are they? One answer lies in Surah al-Nisa’.

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ
وَالصَّادِقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Quran 4:69

The lectures read this verse as naming four ranks of those brought near: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada’*, which Qara’i translates “martyrs” and the lectures take as “the witnesses”; and the righteous (*salihin*). The blessing in question is plainly not wealth or a strong body. It is something else. The first three ranks are frankly beyond us. But the fourth is a doorway. The *salihin* are those with the capacity to receive this favour, and it is from among them, on this reading, that God chooses the truthful and the prophets. Of the Prophet Lut, for example, God says: “And We admitted him into Our mercy. Indeed, he was one of the righteous” (Q 21:75).

This is the hopeful heart of the argument. The prophets and the Imams (‘a) are *muqarrabun* of the highest kind. But ordinary people can also enter the realm of those brought near, even if it is hard to get into that last category. And once they do, the Quran treats them as a different kind of believer. For the *muqarrabun*, “the whole terms and conditions are different”. They are given Paradise in this world, and in the next they are after something more.

The Shia writer Sayyid Haydar Amuli reads the Quran the same way. He notes that the Quran sorts people again and again into threes: the common people, the elite and the elite of the elite; “the people of the right, the people of the left and the intimate”. The true knowers of God, he says, are always the third group. “They are classed as the elite of the elite, the intimate ones and those who go before”²⁰.

²⁰Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 50.



A special class of believers

Here is a question worth asking. Leave aside the prophets and the Imams. Can you think of any verse that describes ordinary believers who are not quite ordinary, people whose understanding is deeper than the rest? Once you start looking, they are everywhere.

إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتُهُ زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ ﴿٢﴾

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned, and when His signs are recited to them, they increase their faith, and who put their trust in their Lord,

Quran 8:2

Is there anyone in the room, a teacher might ask, whose heart trembles at the name of Allah? Even if there were, they would hardly reveal the secret. The point is serious, though. You only tremble at the mention of something you have some experience of. A name means nothing to a heart that does not know whom it names. So the believers of this verse are believers who *know* Allah.

♦ REFLECTION

The Quran says that the faithful are those “whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned” (Q 8:2). We hear the name of Allah dozens of times a day: in the call to prayer, in our own salah, in every “God willing” and “praise be to God”. When did the name last move you? And if it rarely does, what does that say about how well you know the One it names?

Then there is the opening of Surah al-Mu’minun: “Certainly, the faithful have attained salvation—those who are humble in their prayers” (Q 23:1–2). The Arabic word for “humble” here is *khاشi‘*, and it means more than humble. It is someone who is broken, someone in whom something gives way when they stand before God. That happens because of an experience they have had of Him. Which raises the question on which the whole subject turns: can Allah be experienced at all? “This is what mysticism is all about.”

Higher still is one of the great verses of the Quran.



ج
 شَهِدَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَالْمَلَائِكَةُ وَأُولُوا الْعِلْمِ قَائِمًا بِالْقِسْطِ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ ﴿١٨﴾

Allah, maintainer of justice, the Almighty and the All-wise, besides whom there is no god, bears witness that there is no god except Him, and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge.

Quran 3:18

God knows His own oneness. The angels witness it. And so do “those who possess knowledge”, *ulu al-ilm*, which is another name for the ‘urafa’, those who know. We all know that there is no god but Allah. But can our knowledge of *tawhid*, God’s oneness, be compared with God’s knowledge of His own oneness, or with the witnessing of those who possess knowledge? Of course not. Tawhid is simple to say and very hard to grasp. We cannot reach its depths by the intellect alone. Only the soul, once it is awake, can take hold of it. Amuli, as we saw, draws his “elite of the elite” from this same verse²¹. And Imam Khomeini reminds us that the Quran “has many degrees of meanings”, revealed in “70 or 70,000 layers”²². The same verse is understood at one level by one reader and far more deeply by another.

Another verse points the same way: “Only those of Allah’s servants having knowledge fear Him” (Q 35:28). Most of us do fear Allah in some way, but what we really fear is His punishment. The people of this verse fear *Him*, with a fear that is hard to explain. Then there are those whom the Quran calls the friends of God.

أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Quran 10:62

Finally there is the promise in Surah al-Nahl: “Whoever acts righteously, [whether] male or female, should he be faithful, We shall revive him with a good life” (Q 16:97). “Acts righteously” links back to the *salihin*, the righteous who stand at the doorway of nearness. The “good life”, *hayat tayyiba*, is a

²¹Sayyid Haydar Amuli, *Inner Secrets of the Path*, p. 50.

²²Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 130.



clean life, pure of the filth of this world. Its people live in the world but do not live in its filth; they rise above the worldly concerns that infect everyone else. This good life “is what mystics are after”.

These are only a few examples, but they are enough to make the point. The Quran itself describes believers who see, hear and know more than the rest. We cannot deny them, and we are invited to join them.

Seeing the inside of the world

What makes these people different? For an answer we can turn to Imam ‘Ali (‘a), and to a short saying that describes God’s friends, the *awliya’ Allah*. In this book, as in the lectures, the friends of God and the ‘urafa’ are the same people.

*God’s special devotees are those who perceive the world’s reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.*²³

Other people look at the surface of the world. The friends of God look at its inside. Why can they do this, and why can’t we? Because they are not taken up with what the rest of us are taken up with. We need to be careful here. There is nothing wrong, according to the shari‘a, with being rich. The trouble is being *busy* with it. Whoever is absorbed in such things can never reach the station of the friends of God. They have families, friends and a place in society, just as we do. But they never think about themselves; they think about God. In their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

✕ HISTORY: THE NAHJ AL-BALAGHA

The *Nahj al-Balagha* (*The Way of Eloquence*) is a collection of the speeches, letters and sayings of Imam ‘Ali (‘a)²⁴, compiled by al-Sharif al-Radi in 400/1010²⁵. The lectures call the passage about God’s special devotees “sermon 432”. In Tahera Qutbuddin’s edition, which this book uses throughout, it is not a sermon but a short saying, number 3.403 in the chapter of sayings²⁶.

²³Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.

²⁴Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), p. 2.

²⁵Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), p. 26.

²⁶Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), p. 826.



Imam ‘Ali (‘a) describes a kindred group to his companion Kumayl: those who uphold God’s proof on earth. They are few, he says, but great in stature. “Knowledge has led them to real perception, enabling them to touch the spirit of certainty.” In this world “they live in bodies whose spirits are linked to the highest abode”. And then, with deep longing: “Ah! Would that I could see them!”²⁷. Elsewhere he says that such people draw back the veil for the living, “until those who heed them see what most cannot see and hear what most cannot hear”²⁸.

The lectures quote only the opening of this saying and leave the rest for the students to read for themselves, because it is “a very nice prescription” of the friends of God. The “Try this” at the end of this chapter takes up that advice.

Can a human being reach this?

All of this raises the question that matters most to an ordinary reader. Can someone like me reach this level of knowledge and love of God?

Sheikh Bahmanpour answers with a line that is meant to sting. We wrongly call ourselves human beings, he says: “We are not yet human beings.” We begin as animals who have the potential to become human, as the prophets are truly human. That echoes the verse we read earlier, which compared heedless people to cattle. But the sting carries a promise. A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God. God created us with that strength, and He wants us to reach it. The tragedy is that we have become His enemies when we were made to be His friends.

‘Allama Tabataba’i describes where that capacity can lead. Those who become wholly sincere to God are beyond Satan’s reach, because “they see Allah wherever they cast their eyes”²⁹. The receiver, fully repaired, finds God in everything it meets.

Where do we begin? Surprisingly, with words we already know. Think of the whispered prayers of the Imams (‘a). If you read them without knowing who wrote them, you might think they came from someone who had left society and spent his life in a cave, wholly given to God. Yet they come from Imams who lived among people. Here is one line from the Whispered Prayer of the Lovers, in the *Sahifa Sajjadiyya* of Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin (‘a):

²⁷Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.133.

²⁸Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 1.219.1.

²⁹Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 66–67.



*My God, who can have tasted the sweetness of Thy love, then wanted another in place of Thee?*³⁰

If we are after other things, we have not yet tasted that sweetness. Mutahhari notes that Du‘a Kumayl, Du‘a Abu Hamza, the *Sahifa* and the Sha‘ban supplications “all contain the most sublime spiritual ideas”³¹. Most of us recite them every year. Chapter 2 shows that, without knowing it, we have been holding the first textbook of ‘Irfan all along.

Seeking, and nothing else

We can now return to where we began. What is the Islamic path, and what is it not? Sheikh Bahmanpour’s closing words to his first class put it as plainly as possible. ‘Irfan “is actually seeking and nothing else”. It is not about gaining any kind of power, or strengthening the soul so that it can work miracles or *karamat*, the wonders of the saints. He uses a strong word for that ambition: “These are shirk.”

The word sounds severe, but the tradition he stands in uses it the same way. Mutahhari explains that the ‘urafa’ consider it “a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one’s goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself”. He recalls the famous words of Imam ‘Ali (‘a): “My God, I do not worship You in fear of Your Fire, nor in desire for Your Paradise, but I find You worthy of worship so I worship You”³². If even Paradise is not to be the goal, then powers certainly are not.

Other writers come at the question from a different angle. ‘Allama Tabataba’i, discussing how to judge whether a spiritual teacher is genuine, notes that such things as reading minds or foretelling the future “become possible at the beginning of spiritual vision”. But he adds at once that “the stage of proximity to Allah is far away from this stage”, and that they “are not a sign of anybody’s being a favorite of Allah”³³. Shomali, writing about the true ‘arif, says that he “considers these things of no importance”³⁴. The emphasis differs. Sheikh Bahmanpour speaks of the seeker’s intention, and calls the pursuit of such powers shirk. Tabataba’i and Shomali, for their part, speak of

³⁰Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin, *al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya* (trans. Chittick), p. 656.

³¹Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 20.

³²Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.

³³Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.

³⁴Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.



what may appear on the road, and treat it as no measure of nearness to God. Neither makes such things the goal of the path.

What, then, is the seeker seeking? Two things: *ma'rifah*, knowing God, and love of God. These are the two things by which the friends of God fly: a knowledge that keeps increasing and a love that never stops. 'Allama Tabataba'i's definition is the same: "The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him"³⁵. *Lantern of the Path* describes what love does once it takes hold: "When love of Allah takes possession of the innermost being of Allah's bondsman, it empties him of every preoccupation except remembrance of Allah"³⁶.

So the receiver inside us is broken, but it is not missing. The signs are all around us, and the Quran calls us to become the people who catch them. The aim is not to become powerful or remarkable. It is to know God and to love Him. How the seekers set about this, and what they find on the way, is the subject of the rest of this book.

► TRY THIS

The lectures advise reading the rest of Imam 'Ali's saying about God's special devotees for yourself, as "a very nice prescription" of the friends of God. Here it is, after the two lines quoted above:

"They kill desires they fear will kill them and reject pleasures they know will reject them. They find wealth of meager benefit, and other men's gain as loss. They deem the world an enemy when others deem it an ally. They deem the hereafter an ally when others deem it an enemy. God's Book is recognized through them, and they are recognized through God's Book"³⁷.

Read it slowly, one sentence at a time, and take it as it was meant: as a prescription.

³⁵ Mutahhari, Tabataba'i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

³⁶ *Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari'a), p. 88.

³⁷ Imam 'Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.